primary symbol of Islam, even though the hardliners in the Jamaat considered the worship of the Prophet's relic, or even of Sufi shrines, unacceptable. This shrine had become the headquarters of JKLF, just like it had once been, before the insurgency, for Sheikh Abdullah. Reports that heavily armed militants had entered the shrine in October 1993 led to its siege. As negotiations followed to give the government and the militants a suitable closure, tension in the valley led to the imposition of a curfew. But even then, a protest march against the siege by about 400 people in Bijbehara led to, what many claim, unprovoked firing by the BSF. Reportedly, 28 people were killed and 60 or more injured. This was reported the world over and for years, photographs of this incident were used to highlight the Indian Army's 'excesses' in Kashmir. Despite that, negotiations finally brought the Hazratbal siege to an end, and a change in the attitude of at least some quarters (like the JKLF, which announced a ceasefire in 1994 following Yasin Malik's release) and a call for dialogue.

But India's good luck didn't last too long. On 8 March 1995, a siege was laid on Kashmir's most revered Sufi shrine, Charar-e-Sharief, near Shopian in south Kashmir, following information that terrorists had taken over its premises. The shrine is dedicated to the 14th-century saint Sheikh Nur-ud-Din Wali, who along with his mentor Lal Ded, merged Kashmir's Shaivite mystical tradition with Sufism. From then on, Sufi shrines have been revered places of worship. As word spread about the shrine being taken over by militants who showed scant regard for its sanctity, a siege was laid by the army and the police to protect the shrine. But the negotiations with those holed up in the shrine left to junior police officers, led nowhere. Eventually, on 10 May (the day of Eid), a big fire in the area led to burning down of the exquisite walnut carvings in the shrine. The confusion following the fire let the leader of the militants, Mast Gul—from Peshawar and an Afghan war veteran—escape with his band of fanatics to Pakistan, where they were greeted with processions in many cities. It was a botched-up operation, and once again Pakistan used the burning down of the shrine by a fire—that was most likely started by the cornered militants —to claim that India was now targeting the Islamic traditions of the